

Experimental Design, Sampling and Randomization

— Extension Experiments

1. Replication Experiment

As a robustness check, we conduct a replication of the experiment to test the sensitivity of our results to specific design choices of the information treatments ($N = 261$).

For this replication, we had targeted a similar sample size as in our original experiment. However, we faced some challenges with recruiting study participants and were only able to recruit 353 participants, of which 261 completed all components of the study.

In particular, we modify the information given to both Control and Treatment participants so that the instructions clearly state that first movers could agree, disagree, or choose to stay silent. We also remove all data visualizations and instead simply state the summary statistics. These variations make silence more salient to participants in the Control group, generating a weaker information treatment that is potentially closer to realistic settings in which silence is noticeable but not highlighted. Aside from the design of the information treatments, the structure and protocols of the rest of the replication were identical to the original experiment. One exception is that we updated one of the topics discussed in the Zoom sessions, swapping the original topic around Covid vaccines, which was not as relevant in 2025, for a new topic around legalizing marijuana.

2. Silence and Polarization

We conduct an additional experiment ($N = 158$) where we allow private and public expression for each topic to occur on a 5-point scale, ranging from strongly disagree to strongly agree, to allow participants to convey not only the direction but also the strength of their opinions. We follow a similar design to our main experiment, except that public expression now takes the form of survey responses that are publicly shared with other study participants.

We use a two-stage survey to elicit private beliefs, public expressions and perceived belief distribution, on the same four topics that we tested in the main experiment.

We first elicit private beliefs and guesses about other students' views in a baseline survey. Instead of a binary "agree" or "disagree" option, participants are provided with a 5-point Likert scale, ranging from "strongly agree" to "strongly disagree". They are then incentivized to guess, "Among other Berkeley students who participate in this study, what

fraction do you think would privately answer ‘strongly agree’, ‘somewhat agree’, ‘neither agree nor disagree’, ‘somewhat disagree’, ‘strongly disagree’ respectively?” for each statement.

Following the same procedure as the original experiment, we randomly assign participants who complete the baseline survey into a First Movers group, Control group, or Treatment group. In the follow-up survey, which is sent one week after the baseline survey, we elicit First Movers’ public expression decisions. Participants are asked to share their opinions on a subset of topics, where their survey responses will be shared publicly with all other study participants. Participants also have the option to stay silent, or not share their opinion, for each topic. Specifically, they are informed that: *“Your answers will be shared publicly with other students participating in the study. Feel free to skip the questions if you don’t want to answer it or if you don’t want to share your answers with other students.”* A key difference from the main experiment is that students can choose their response from the 5-point scale rather than the original binary scale.

As in the main experiment, we randomly vary the salience of silence when presenting summary statistics about First Movers’ public expression to Second Movers in the follow-up survey. The number of students who skipped the public expression question for each topic is highlighted in the Treatment group information but not in the Control group information. Second Movers then guess, incentivized for accuracy, the percentage of Berkeley participants who would privately choose each option, ranging from “strongly agree” to “strongly disagree.” They are also asked to provide their own opinions on the same 5-point scale which are made public to the other study participants.

3. Berkeley Building Name Review Committee

In this follow-up experiment, we conducted a brief survey with Berkeley students to understand their private views, perceptions about others’ views, and public expression decisions on renaming Berkeley buildings. We first elicit students’ private views. Participants are asked if they agree or disagree with the following statement: *“All Berkeley buildings named after controversial historical figures should be renamed.”*

We then share summaries of this public discussion with students, where we randomly vary which version of the information intervention students receive. In total, 255 participants were randomly assigned to one of three groups of equal size: 1) Control, which omits the number of confidential comments; 2) Treatment, which includes the number of all three types of comments; or 3) Omit Agree, which omits the number of public agreement comments in the summary pie charts that are shared with participants.

As in the main experiment, we inform students in all three groups of the total number of comments. Thus, the number of comments belonging to the omitted category can be inferred, at least in theory, and the total amount of information available across groups is the same. The only difference across groups is which expression categories are more salient in the summary statistics shared with participants.

After presenting the information interventions, we incentivize students to guess the belief distribution by asking them *“Among other Berkeley students who participate in this survey, what percentage do you think privately ‘agree’ and ‘disagree’ with the following statement: ‘All Berkeley buildings named after controversial historical figures should be renamed’”*.

Finally, we elicit participants’ public expression decisions by asking them to sign a petition that is either in favor of or against the renaming of other Berkeley buildings. The petition that participants receive depends on their private beliefs. For example, those who privately agree with renaming are presented with a petition titled *“Don’t Stop at Moses: Remove ALL Racist Names from UC Berkeley NOW”*, and those who privately disagree receive a petition titled *“Please Don’t Erase our History in UC Berkeley.”* Participants are informed that the petitions are likely to be shared with the Berkeley Building Name Review Committee and, if they choose to sign the petition, they must do so with their real names and Berkeley email addresses.